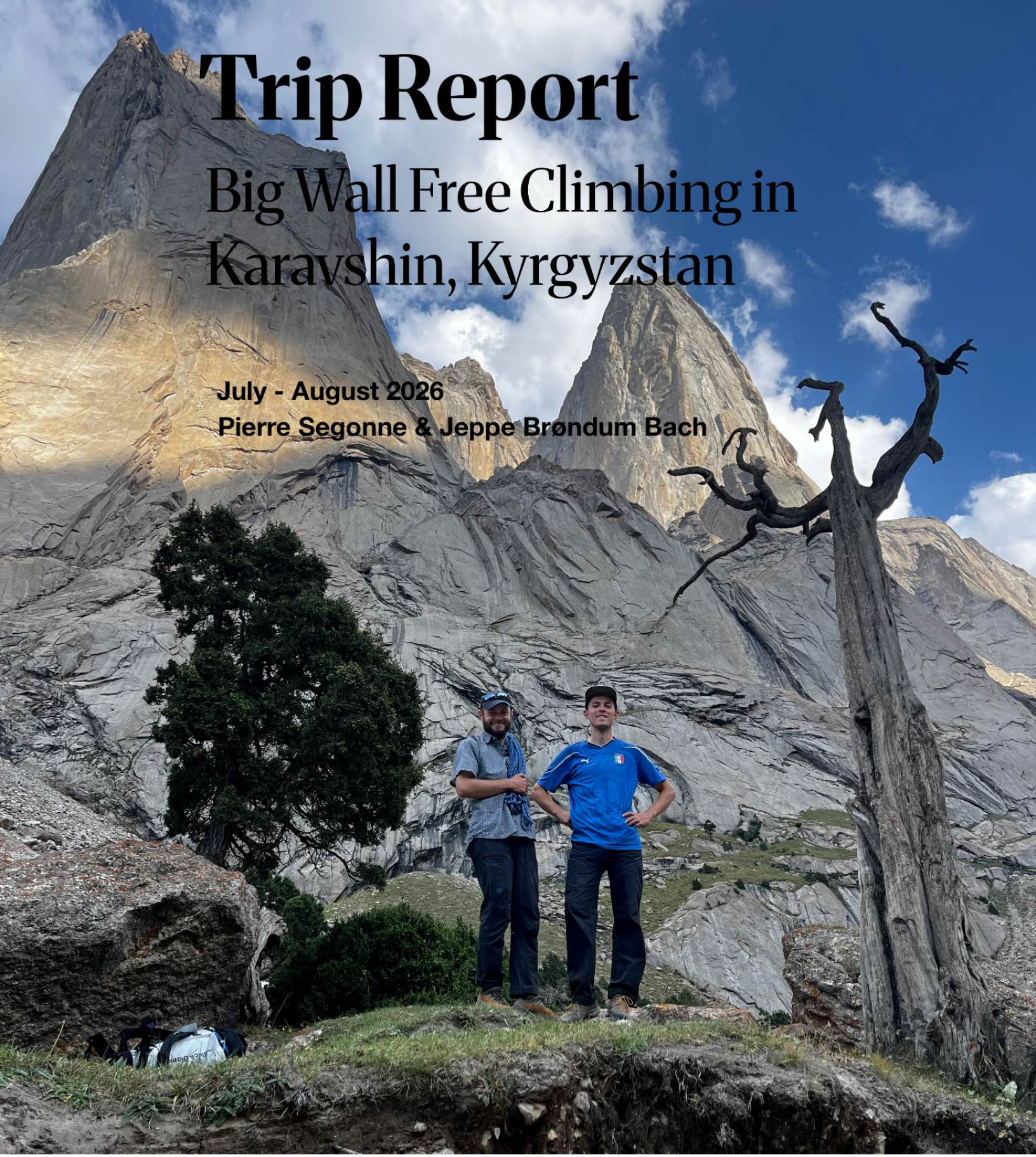
Trip Report

Big Wall Free Climbing in Karavshin, Kyrgyzstan



July - August 2026

Pierre Segonne & Jeppe Brøndum Bach

Dansk Bjerg- og Klatreklub

FRILUFTSLAND

Summary.... 4
List of Ascents.... 5
About Karavshin.... 6
History.... 7
Geography and noteworthy summits.... 9
Logistics.... 11
To use a travel agency or not?.... 12
Base camp life.... 14
Location.... 14
Tents.... 14
Electronics and WiFi.... 15
Food.... 16
Staff.... 16
Getting supplies to base camp.... 17
Hygiene.... 17
Day by day activities.... 18
Jul 14, 2026 Arrival.... 18
Jul 15, 2026 Onto Basecamp.... 20
Jul 16, 2026 The French Route on the Little Russian Tower.... 22
Jul 17, 2026 The Missing Mountain on Pamir Pyramid.... 24
Jul 18, 2026 Rest and stashing gear for Perestroika Crack.... 27
Jul 19, 2026 Perestroika Crack on the Russian Tower: day one.... 28
Jul 20, 2026 Perestroika Crack on the Russian Tower: day two.... 29
Jul 21, 2026 How to save the base camp from mud flows.... 34
Jul 22, 2026 Rain and rest.... 35
Jul 23, 2026 Umay Ene: scouting the approach.... 35
Jul 24, 2026 Walking up to the glacier.... 36
Jul 25, 2026 Umay Ene: a first attempt.... 36
Jul 26, 2026 Rest.... 38
Jul 27, 2026 Take It Easy on the Central Pyramid.... 38
Jul 28, 2026 Une Lune Pour Tamerlan on the Wall of Dykes.... 40
Jul 29, 2026 Rest, Stashing gear for Potankina on Kirkchilta.... 42
Jul 30, 2026 Potankina on Kirkchilta: day one.... 42
Jul 31, 2026 Potankina on Kirkchilta: day two.... 45
Aug 1, 2026 Potankina on Kirkchilta: day three.... 47

Aug 2, 2026 Rest..... 49
Aug 3, 2026 Rest, and party at base camp..... 49
Aug 4, 2026 Rain and rest..... 50
Aug 5, 2026 The American Way on The Russian Tower..... 50
Aug 6, 2026 Matas on Umay Ene..... 52
Aug 7, 2026 Rest..... 56
Aug 8, 2026 The Middle Route on the Little Russian Tower..... 57
Aug 9, 2026 Transfer to Kara-Su..... 57
Aug 10, 2026 West Face Corner and Cracks on Little Asan..... 58
Aug 11, 2026 Ak-Kalpak on Little Asan..... 59
Aug 12, 2026 Sourire Kirghize on Yellow Wall..... 61
Aug 13, 2026 Transfer back to Ak-Su..... 63
Aug 14, 2026 Farewell, Karavshin..... 65
Notable ascents that summer..... 65
Reflexions on the development of Karavshin..... 65
Kyrgyzstan and Visas..... 66
Acknowledgments..... 68

Summary

In July and August 2026, Our team, Pierre Segonne and Jeppe Brøndum Bach, spent four weeks climbing in the Ak-Su and Kara-Su valleys of the Karavshin region, Pamir-Alay. After warming up on the Little Russian Tower (The French Route, 290m, 6c) and Pamir Pyramid (The Missing Mountain, 600m, 6b), they completed a clean, two-day free ascent of the classic Perestroika Crack (800m, 7b) on the Russian Tower (Slesova). On Umay Ene, they opened a new 8-pitch line, Matas (350m, 7a), following a prominent corner and roof system on the upper wall. The pair also made an impressive three-day ascent of the 1,500m Potankina route (7a) on Kirkchilta (Peak 1000 Years of Russian Christianity), bivouacking near the arete and below the summit before rappelling the route. Further ascents included Take It Easy (200m, 7a) on the Central Pyramid and the Middle Route (290m, 6c) on the Little Russian Tower, along with attempts on Une Lune Pour Tamerlan (Wall of Dykes), The American Way (Russian Tower), West Face Corner and Cracks, and Ak-Kalpak (Little Asan). They concluded their trip in Kara-Su with a team ascent of Sourire Kirghize (600m, 7b) on the Yellow Wall alongside Norwegian climbers Severin Schirmer and Nikolai Atkinson.

List of Ascents

- Jul 16, 2026 Little Russian Tower - The French Route - 290m, 6c max - onsight - very soft (6a+/b)
- Jul 17, 2026 Pamir Pyramid - The Missing Mountain - 600m, 6b max - onsight - quite soft (6b)
- Jul 19, 2026 to Jul 20, 2026 Russian Tower - Perestroika Crack - 800m, 7b max - onsight - very soft (6c+/7a)
- Jul 27, 2026 Central Pyramid - Take it Easy - 200/300m, 7a max - onsight - very soft (6b+)
- Jul 28, 2026 Wall of Dykes - Une Lune Pour Tamerlan - 280m, 7a max - retreat - correctly graded but on the stiffer end
- Jul 30, 2026 to Aug 1, 2026 Kirkchilta - Potankina - 1500m, 7a max, onsight - soft (6c)
- Aug 5, 2026 Russian Tower - The American Way - 900m, 7c+ max, retreat - correctly graded
- Aug 6, 2026 Umay Ene - Matas - 350m, 7a max - onsight FA - graded a bit soft to be consistent with the most classic Ak-Su routes
- Aug 8, 2026 Little Russian Tower - The Middle Route - 290m, 6c max - onsight - very soft (6a+/b)
- Aug 10, 2026 Little Asan - Corners and Cracks - 400m, 7b+ max - retreat - correctly graded?
- Aug 11, 2026 Little Asan - Al Kalpak - 280m, 8a+ max - retreat - correctly graded
- Aug 12, 2026 Yellow Wall - Un Sourire Kirghize - 600m, 7b max - top with hangs - correctly graded, but on the stiffer end.

About Karavshin



Views of the Karavshin Gorge. In the distance, the Kotina - Kirkchilta - Odesa ridge splits Ak-Su (left) and Kara-Su (right)

Karavshin (Каравшин) is a deep gorge of the Turkestan range, which is itself part of the Pamir-Alay system, and offers some of the finest big wall climbing in the world. It is a true and improbable wonder of nature, where all conditions are united to make climbing so wonderful.

While the Turkestan range is itself mostly constituted of chossy limestone and shale, eroded granite plutons emerge in the two upper valleys that feed into Karavshin, Ak-Su (Ак-Суу) and Kara-Su (Кара-суу). The clean, steep and imposing granite walls of these valleys thus seem to appear out of a climber's dream in the ocean of choss surrounding it.

The lower part of the gorge is further extremely arid. Black, burned rocks and desperate shrubs are the only things offering bits of contrast to the desertic and eroded landscape. Traveling up along the riverbed, one escapes this uninviting environment, and eventually reaches the base camp, nested in a temperate and welcoming alpine meadow, with streams running clear within a stone's throw and fragrant cypress trees offering shade and firewood.

The climate is cooperative, with mostly dry and fair weather, and temperate temperatures for most of the summer season. We were told that July 15 - August 15 offers the best weather windows.

History

The area has probably been inhabited seasonally by local nomads who seemingly practice a form of alpine transhumance, taking their sheep and cows up to the alpine meadows (called Jailoo in Kyrgyz) of Ak-Su / Kara-Su during summer. Walking through these valleys, one can spot many ruins of Kosh (temporary residence for herders, close to the pastures), suggesting that the valleys were seeing prolific nomadic activity in centuries past.



Herders of fat-tailed sheep still bring their flocks to the alpine pastures of Karavshin

The first recorded expedition to the area dates back to 1936. A soviet geological survey team prospected the area for valuable metals, and included some of the prominent alpinists of the time (e.g. Vitaly Abalakov) to guide the team. An attempt was made on the Peak Pirimidalny, the most prominent summit of the area, towering over the end of the Kara-Su valley, but was unsuccessful.

The area was seemingly re-discovered in 1982 by aerial reconnaissance (link), which led climbers in the years following. Notably, the Soviet mountaineering championships were held there for a few years after 1987 (link). The format can feel a bit like an oddity compared to our current practices; on a given year, a specific face was selected, judges established at its base, and teams of climbers would have to pick their way up the face, with total freedom on how to progress. That led to the establishment of many hard aid routes, seldom repeated, as most of them, not being so evident, follow sections of aid climbing on drilled bat hooks, and are poorly documented.

Free climbing was introduced to the valley in the 90s by visiting teams of western climbers. In 1991, a Spanish expedition established new routes in the valley, most famously Perestroika Crack, which was later freed during the 1994 French youth expedition of the Groupe de Haute Montagne (link, link). In 1996, a star-struck American climbing expedition brought even more awareness to the potential of the valley as a prime bigwall & free climbing destination. Unfortunately, it seems that much information has been lost about some of the routes freed by

that expedition (ex: Clod Hopper Direct on the Central Pyramid by Lynn Hill and Greg Child going at grade 6, Fat City, 18 pitches, by Jay Smith and Kitty Calhoun-Grissom going at 5.12, the Bastion on Odesa, 1200m by Lynn Hill and Alex Lowe going at 5.12b, or an unnamed route on the south face of Odesa by Jay Smith, Kitty Calhoun-Grissom and Dan Osman going at 5.11)

Climbing in Karavshin came to a halt in the early 2000s. The Islamic Movement of Uzbekistan (IMU) carved itself some space in the unrest that followed the dissolution of the Soviet Union, and, backed by the Taliban-controlled Afghanistan gathered enough strength to strike in Uzbekistan and Kyrgyzstan. The western part of Kyrgyzstan, where Karavshin lies, hosts numerous ethnic Uzbeks and was thus a prime target for the movement. In 1999, they kidnapped the mayor of Osh (Ош), as well as some Japanese geologists. In 2000, the kidnapping and escape of American climbers Beth Rodden, Tommy Caldwell, Jason Smith and John Dickey brought the valley into the limelight, but in a dark fashion. While trying to establish a new route on the Yellow wall of Kara-Su, the climbers were shot at from the valley and forced to come down. Followed a six-day gruesome flight for the climbers, escorted by their IMU captors, only interrupted by deadly skirmishes with the Kyrgyz military. Eventually, the climbers were left with only one captor while scrambling up to a ridge. The captor, not being comfortable in such terrain, let his guard down. That allowed Tommy Caldwell to push him off a cliff, into the void, making it possible for the climbers to find shelter in a Kyrgyz army barrack. (link).

The IMU lost most of its strength following the 2001-2002 invasion of Afghanistan (link), which later allowed climbers to return to Karavshin. New expeditions continued to push the boundaries of free climbing in the valley: The Pustelnik brothers established Amba in 2006 (1100m, 7c/7c+ max) (link); in 2020, Eric Bissel, Nik Berry, David Allfrey and Brent Barghahn equipped and freed a variation of the Russian Shield / Moroz Route on the Russian Tower, the American Way (950m, 5.13a max) (link); in 2022, Patrick Tirler and Moritz Sigmund opened Al Kalpak on Little Asan (280m, 8a+ max) (link).

Many more climbing lines are yet to be explored or freed in the valley, so it is expected that this short history of the valley will soon be incomplete.

Geography and noteworthy summits



Right bank of Ak-Su

- Ortotyubek (Ортотюбек)
    - Central Pyramid
- Little Russian Tower
- Russian Tower or Slesova (Слесова)
    - Pamir Pyramid or Peak 3700
- Wall of Dykes or Peak 3850
- Bird or Ptitsa (Птица)

Shared between Ak-Su and Kara-Su

- Odesa or Peak 4810 (Одесса)
    - Peak 4300

- Kirkchilta or Peak 1000 years of Russian christianity or Peak 4510 (Киркчилта)
    - Umay Ene
- Kotina (Котина)

Right bank of Kara-Su

- Asan or Peak 4320 (Асан)
    - Little Asan
- Usan (Усан)
- Pyramidalny or Peak 5509 (Пирамидальный)

Left bank of Kara-Su

- Silver Wall (Серебряная стена)
    - Green Wall
- Yellow Wall (Желтая стена)

Logistics

The Karavshin valley is not as remote as one could imagine. Travelling from Osh to the base camp takes two days. A first day is needed to drive from Osh to the feet of the mountains (4 or 5 hours of driving on paved roads). A second day is needed to drive into the mountains, over a high mountain pass, on dirt roads and hike up to the base camp.

On the dirt-road meandering in the mountains, last glimpses of human life







[Here]() you can find a map that details the different parts of the journeys.

Horses being readied for the resupply of base camp



On the last stretch of the journey, horses are brought in to carry the gear. Each horse can carry up to 60 kgs, so make sure that your bags match the allotted horses, otherwise you'll have to repack and potentially leave some gear behind to be brought up at a later point.





To use a travel agency or not?

As this was our first expedition, we wanted to offload as much of the logistical concerns to our travel agency as possible. This meant that the logistics were completely covered for us, from the Osh international airport until our arrival at the base camp.

At our arrival, we were picked up at the airport, driven to a guest house to relax and rest for the next day, after having stopped at our request in a supermarket to get supplies (snacks, hygiene goods etc).
The next day, we were picked up again at the guest house and driven to the end of the road. There, horsemen took charge of our gear and we only had to follow the long trail ahead to reach the base camp. All in all, a pretty smooth experience.
The downside of this is that we were mostly kept in the dark throughout the journey. Due to the language barrier (few speak English), or perhaps cultural inclinations, we were left with very little information of what was ahead of us. And we had to suffer some of the consequences of that. For example, not knowing what we needed to buy for the base camp, we overbought some unnecessary items (like toilet paper), thus exceeding the total baggage weight suitable for the horses, and had to bear ourselves groceries on the hike up to base camp. We also did not know about the specifics of the approach, and thus had no food and not enough water for us for the 6 hour hike up - pretty dumb in a stifling 40°C heat.

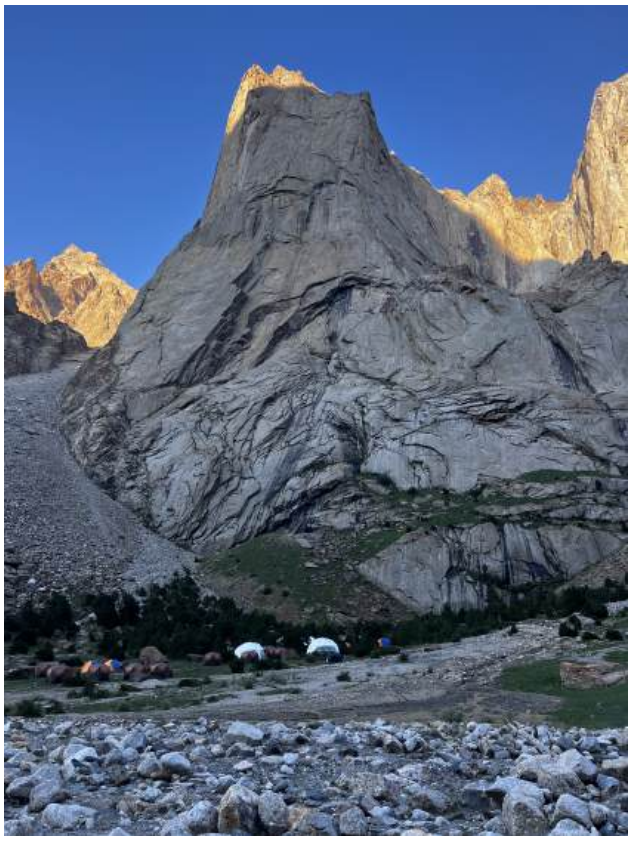
From what we've heard it's possible to organise all the logistics independently, but would require one to understand the journey well, and probably speak some Russian to be able to communicate on the fly with the drivers and horsemen and make sure they understand one's needs.

Note: the access road has changed in the early 2020s, it is no longer required to start in Özgörüsh and hike for two days to access the base camp. That's because they opened a new gravel road up a 3000m pass which shortens the approach to a single day hike.

Base camp life

In 2026, the travel agency Central Asia Tours had a monopoly on the base camp of Ak-Su, with Ak-Sai Travel competing with them in Kara-Su.

From what we could see, both established base camps offered similar amenities.



Ak-Su base camp, sitting at the foot of Ortotyubek

Location

Ak-Su: 39.60976, 70.2935 (3000m)
Kara-Su: 39.64303, 70.27608 (2900m)

Tents

On our arrival to Ak-su, Jeppe and I were told to pick any free tent to sleep in and host our gear, and assigned a mess tent to enjoy our meals and lounge.

There were two types of sleeping tents, and luckily we got to enjoy the more spacious one. These yurt-style tents, supposed to host five people, offered us more than enough space. Not all of those tents were pitched equally well though. Some were on slanted terrain, others were at risk of being thrashed by mudflows and others weren't pitched with enough stakes to withstand the wind.
We, and people we befriended along the way, all had to suffer from some of these mishaps. Jeppe and I had to move our tent as we were afraid that the mud coming down from the couloir between Slesova and Ortutubyek would wreck our tent, and unfortunately the only suitable spot we found was quite rocky, uneven ground. Later, Severin saw the roof of his tent fly out from above him as he was peacefully lying down and reading. Seeing him run for help with the tent flying in the background was quite the scene.



Inside of the more spacious mess tent

Mess tents were very simply organized, with enough tables and seating space; common usable items (tissues, toilet paper); and an antiquated battery, that would (sometimes) recharge with an underpowered solar panel, and featuring USB-A type sockets.



A common sight at base camp: Jeppe reading a Sherlock Holmes story

Electronics and WiFi

The camp had further larger solar panels, powering larger and more reliable batteries, open for common use. At first, these batteries, through a little transformer, would power, whenever there was sun, the starlink router and provide WiFi to the camp. Unfortunately, the transformer died midway through the trip, so WiFi became a rare commodity through the last two weeks. It was only turned on when the back-up generator was in use.

For Kara-Su, there is no WiFi directly at the camp, but a Kosh (herder's hut) has a starlink router, which they turn on when asked (and whey they don't need the power for something else - e.g. washing their clothes)

Food

Three meals are served per day at base camp. Breakfast, served when asked (between 07:00 and 09:00), typically either eggs and sausage, eggs and crepes, or some sort of porridge. Lunch was often the lightest meal of the day, served around 13:30 -14:30. Stews (borsch or shorpo) or pasta were most often served then. Dinner was most often served around 8, and again mainly consisted of Kyrgyz specialties, such as manty, kuurdak, buckwheat or pilaf/plov. The food was generally simple yet tasty (but not so accommodating for true vegetarians!). The only recurring complaint was about quantities, especially in Ak-Su. The plates were simply insufficiently filled for hungry climbers.
Note that the mess tents featured at all times complementary snacks (mostly nuts, tea biscuits and snack bars) as well as instant coffee and tea (with milk powder substitute and condensed milk).

Staff

Locals oversee and man the base camps. They're typically families living in the valley for the rest of the year, and coming up to work at the base camp during summer. In Ak-Su, Айжан (Aijan) and Баймурза (Baimurza) were extremely helpful, and willing to make the life at base camp as enjoyable as possible. The language barrier can be limiting for those who don't have a single team member speaking Russian, but luckily Айжан is an English teacher the rest of the year and has thus proved invaluable to fix any of our problems.



Farewell picture with Айжан and Баймурза

Getting supplies to base camp

Horse caravans travel almost daily between the upper valleys of Ak-Su and Kara-Su and the point where the road stops. It's therefore possible to ask staff at the base camp to arrange deliveries of supplies during the expedition. Don't expect next-day-delivery-Amazon-style type of service, but the result is the same - one will get its order after a few days.
Basic supplies can be directly bought from the base camp staff. Ex: Cola, crips (300 soms), beers (500 soms).

Hygiene

Toilets (a hole in the ground) and showers (small electric hose fed from a barrel) are provided by the travel agency.



Jeppe enjoying a well deserved shower in Kara-Su

Going to Karavshin (and Kyrgyzstan in general from what I've subsequently heard) will be a tough challenge for your digestive track.
You can almost see it as a part of acclimatization. People generally catch the Karavshin stomach bug after a day or two at base camp, have a really bad day (or night) and then feel mostly fine afterwards.

My personal hypothesis is that there's nothing particularly harmful in the food nor water, but more of a bug going around and that your body needs to learn to tame. The reason for this is that people rarely get sick more than once, unlike what one would expect if the food/water itself was harmful.

Day by day activities

Jul 14, 2026 Arrival

We landed at Osh's airport around 6 in the morning, after a very short night of sleep.
By around 7 we were out of the airport, and hoped to find someone to pick us up. At first, it seemed that no one was there. One by one, all the drivers carrying signs with travel agencies' names left. Anxiety started creeping in, what if it was a scam?
We double checked all our communications with our contact - no information was provided to us as to what we should expect at the airport, even though we had reached out the day prior asking exactly that. To top it up, the airport WiFi was as stable as someone on a unicycle. Time passed, nothing. Jeppe went out to try to fetch some cash and get his hands on a local SIM card, while Pierre checked over and over all the emails with the travel agency.
Eventually, we found out that the only way to contact them directly was through Telegram. Our message was seen, which left us nervously waiting for an answer, as we could our contact's status as "writing" for minutes on end. Finally - it all made sense, we were to expect someone with a sign of a different travel agency than the one we were in contact with. They were just intermediaries.
Just a few meters from us, we eventually spotted a middle-aged man, half dozing with a sign saying "Central Asia Tours" - that was it. Ironically, he got angry at us when we approached him, for being late, although we had been right in front of him for the whole 30 minutes. Never once he thought to approach the obviously confused outdoorsy foreigners, the only ones left at the airport.
But all was fine, trust the process we thought, trust the process.

A few minutes later, we hopped on a pick-up truck and we managed to get him to understand that we'd like to stop at a supermarket for groceries. We hopped off, and once inside, started frantically throwing as many snacks as we could find in our shopping trolley. Snickers here, dates there, M&Ms, dried fruits and nuts, not so exotic after all. Once at the checkout, the power jumped and we had to wait 20 minutes or so.
Again, our dear driver Majid was not so pleased about that extra delay, even though that gave him a good opportunity for a nap.



Kyrgyz landscapes

Finally, we headed off out of Osh and dry and grassy landscapes appeared. After an hour or so of driving, we stopped on the side of the road, and Majid got out of the car. A young man replaced him without really explaining to us what was going on. Trust the process we thought.

He turned the volume up, started blasting some Kyrgyz rap, and carried us at full speed (up to 150km/h) to our final destination of the day, “Guest house, relax”.

Relax we did, for there was not much else to do.



Enjoying our first decent meal since we left France at the Guest House

Jul 15, 2026 Onto Basecamp

We woke up to find that we had been joined by a large group of Catalans.
After a hearty breakfast, we were told that it was time to leave. Back in the same pick-up truck, brimming with excitement, knowing that by the evening, we would be at the feet of the mountains we had been dreaming about for months.

For three hours, we were shaken like limp potato bags by the harsh roads of the Turkestan. We stopped midway in some alpine valley and saw our driver deliver water melons and other goods to some herders. Again, no explanation. Again, Trust the process we thought.



Waiting for the horsemen at the end of the road

We were dropped off at the end of the road - which felt like the end of the world. An hour, two, passed under the shelter of a corrugated metal sheet. The heat was suffocating and again, we were left in the dark as to what was happening. Eventually, all the pick up trucks left us, even though at this point only two horses or so had arrived - for 10 people.

Trust the process we thought.
And that worked, for an hour later all our gear was loaded on the horses and we were setting off for the approach hike with water melon, bread and tea as refreshment (for those who dared ingest that).

Unaware of the exact weight horses could carry (we were told “Don’t worry my friend” by the travel agency), we ended up, with the supplies from the supermarket, exceeding the 60 kg acceptable for the horse that was allotted to us. So on our own back it went.



Horses at the start of the hike

That made the hike even more strenuous. While the terrain is not so steep, the Karavshin gorge is a hostile place. The heat is unavoidable, as no shade is to be found, and everything around screams of death - ruins, burned rocks and remnants of sheep flocks. To top it, Misfortune struck hard. Jeppe randomly lost a sandal that was attached to his backpack, realised it, and while running back to see if he could find it, lost his newly gifted camera to the tumultuous waters of the Karavshin river.



An upset Jeppe

We thus arrived at the base camp right before sunset, shriveled like raisins, short-breathed and in a dismal mood. We only needed to lift our gazes though to be taken by wonder. Above us were towering monoliths of granite, left and right, of such heights that it was impossible to comprehend. Slesova, Odesa, Kirkchilta, they were all there, and never had we seen such a concentration of steep and inviting-looking granite. That was what we were here for.

Jul 16, 2026 The French Route on the Little Russian Tower

The alarm rang, not long. We snoozed it to get an extra hour of sleep. The hike had strained us, and we still felt the effect of the time shift. Another hour would do.

Groggy, we swallowed our first breakfast in the company of some of the early risers of the Catalan group and set off for our warm-up climb: The French Route of the Little Russian Tower (290m, 6c max).

While still being in the shadows of the mountains, we could see that we would be welcomed in the valley by a sunny and fair day. An hour later, we were at the feet of the face, stricken by three 100m+ obvious crack systems, the most splitter-like being the left one, the one we had decided to ascend. Perfect.

Our slow start meant that we were not the first ones to get there; a group of eight Russians were already setting off. Luckily, some of them spoke English and were really friendly. They were all going on the two right-most routes, so that we did not have to actually wait to start climbing.



Pierre seconding in the French Route

Overflowing with excitement, the first easier pitches (5+, 5+) went in a blip - the climbing was secure (albeit a few loose blocks at the start), on good cracks, and good fun, as it is always when one climbs flowy moderate crack routes.

Followed three pitches following the splitter crack on the left. Quite grassy at the start, which made for a new style of climbing we would encounter again and again while in Karavshin: Find the hole that has been dug out in the dirt and bushes, jam there, get your feet high on the previous hole, and

repeat. The crux of the route consists in passing first a slight roof opened by an off-width crack (6b), and then proceeding up the long off-width section (6b/c). This is one of the finest pitches found in the valley. Continuous, on a perfect #5 width, providing bomber knee locks all the way.



Jeppe on the start of THE pitch of the French Route

Luckily, we found out there that the granite of Karavshin is generally quite featured and one can often find some crystals or chicken heads, providing much welcome help for the offwidth sections.

We were then confused about the last two pitches, not finding that what we saw was matching the topo; the 6c pitch felt much easier than what came before, and the last 6a felt a bit contrived.

Pierre on the upper part of the French Route



Our warm-up was a confirmation; we were in good shape, able to run up (softly graded) crack routes in good flow. We thus became hungry for something bigger, and more ambitious.

The weather looked promising for the next few days - so we began enquiring at base camp about Perestroika Crack. As for us, the route is a must-do for most people coming to the valley, so it can get crowded during good weather windows. There is a good bivy ledge midway up the route, and most people choose to spend a first day climbing up to the ledge, sleep there and then, on a second day, climb to the top and rappel down. This ledge is only so big; three people can sleep there lying down, up to five/six awkwardly sitting. Unfortunately for us, three Chileans (Raimundo de Andraca, Fernanda Carabias, Diego Saez) were already on the route and some of the Catalans (Estel Pares, Pau Herrero, Samu and Jiusep) had stated that they wanted to give it a go as well.
So that meant that we needed to exercise a bit of patience and keep warming up.

Jul 17, 2026 The Missing Mountain on Pamir Pyramid

We thus decided to report our attention to a more moderate route - The Missing Mountain on Pamir Pyramid (600m, 6b max). A short approach, moderate climbing, topping out just below Perestroika Crack, what's not to like?
This route showed us for the first time how hard it can be to piece information out about established routes in Karavshin. Information is spread out across many different sources (American Alpine Journal, Social Media, The Mountain Project, TheCrag, UKC etc), with topos often drawn in a corner of a tent. Luckily a young French team who took to Karavshin by train in 2019 (report here) assembled a somewhat comprehensive topo (accessible here).

Note: since then, we have added some consistency and comprehensiveness to the publicly accessible online topo bases (see more in Section "Reflexions about the development of Karavshin")

The information in that topo confused us, creating a misunderstanding between us. Jeppe thought we were about to climb Lazzy Lizard, while Pierre was more set on climbing the Missing Mountain. But we were looking at the same route! On the French topo, both routes are described using the same drawn topo. A mystery that still eludes us.

A short approach through the old base camp led us to the foot of the Pamir Pyramid. Finding the start of the route proved trickier than expected - no gear in place, nor signs of recent passage. After scouting for 10-15 mins, we decided to trust our instinct and set off under a system of cracks interspersed with almost featureless sections.
After a few meters of climbing, it became evident to Pierre, who was leading, that this was the right way - the featureless sections were not so, offering horizontal cracks that were hard to spot from the ground.



Pierre at the start of the Missing Mountain

A first pitch led us to a grassy ledge, where again, we pondered where we were supposed to continue. There was supposed to be a bolted anchor there, but we missed it entirely and instead continued up a groove further to the left. The climbing was not so sustained, and not so steep terrain, but pleasant and flowy.

A few more pitches led us up right under the significant dihedral we had scouted from the pictures. There we eventually found a bolted anchor; we had made our own variation to the start, all on gear.



Jeppe cruising up the start slabs of the Missing Mountain

The dihedral offered glorious climbing, with foot holds and perfect jams appearing as needed (6a).
After that, we simul-climbed the easier pitches (5b) until we reached the lunch-ledge.

Pierre in the middle of the 200 meters dihedral



A most formidable dihedral was towering us - never had we seen something like that in the Alps. 200m of corners and dihedrals were to take us to the top. The climbing there was even more enjoyable, as it was more vertical, and three-dimensional, due to the many flakes one needs to swing around (6a-6a+). The last real pitch turned out to be more committing than expected as we had not really carried any large cams (6b). Following the roof closing the top of the dihedral came a few steps of wide cracks, made harder due to the rope drag.



Last difficulty, a roof followed by wide cracks

In good time, we were on top of Pamir Pyramid, looking with envy at the start of Perestroika Crack. A blank, white-streaked shield of granite showing as only weakness a 250m splitter crack. No longer would we wait, no matter what, we would engage in our futile dance with the Russian Tower as soon as possible.

Jul 18, 2026 Rest and stashing gear for Perestroika Crack

Guided by this newfound determination, we meticulously prepared our gear for the upcoming climb. Never had we attempted a climb requiring so many logistical considerations. In the alps, our go-to strategy was always to climb in a day, no matter how long and strenuous that day be. Here, that would not be enough.

Haul system, check. Bivouac gear, check. Water, check. And the list goes on.

Before heading out, we checked on the other parties at base camp. Another rope team of three Russians were already on their way up, and planning to use three days. That meant they would be on the ledge by the evening of the following day, and that we would all have a seated, cramped, terrible night if we were to climb the route in the most common style. We adapted, for everyone's comfort.
We would only climb the first few pitches up to the shoulder on the first day, bivy there, and climb all the Russian Tower proper in a single day. Better style.

And so we went up to carry our 20kgs+ packs each to the base of the route. Surprisingly, the path up the giant talus was not as ankle-breaking as some made it out to be.



Pierre showering in the frigid water, that was before we knew there was a shower at base camp

Jul 19, 2026 Perestroika Crack on the Russian Tower: day one

With most of our gear already at the base of Perestroika Crack, we could enjoy the base camp life in the morning; waking up late, eating pancakes and eggs, waiting for the sun to warm up the dew-spotted tents, a book in hand.

Lunch came late that day, and we thus only reached the base of the climb around 17:00. More than three hours to climb three or four easy pitches would be no issue, we thought. Oh were we wrong.

Pierre climbed the first pitch, but as soon as he started hauling, the bag got stuck under a small roof, out of Jeppe's reach. Our inexperience in hauling showing, we tried to free up the bag and lower it back to the start anchor, to have Jeppe help the bag stay out of obstacles. In

doing so, the haul bag suddenly dropped a few meters, and the haul line (a 6mm Rad line) burned Pierre's little finger, who let go of what he had in hand: one of the two micro-tractions. Rough start, as could be heard through our colourful swears.
Luckily, we had taken a jumar as a back-up, which we used to proceed up the easy three original pitches (5+ max).
The climbing was slow, with the one climbing second having to stay close to the haul bag to help it stay clear of the many features on the way. We eventually made it to the five stars bivy spot found right under the top of the Pamir Pyramid, overlooking the shoulder. An alpine cigarette later we were relaxed again, and enjoying the awe inspiring views of the upper Ak-Su valley in a perfectly still weather.



Relaxed, at last, after our worst hauling experience

Thinking back to it, it would probably have been easier to simply climb with all the gear on our backs. We subsequently heard from other several teams that it worked well for them (Lorin Etzel and Kassandra)

Jul 20, 2026 Perestroika Crack on the Russian Tower: day two

The alarm rings, 4:00, just in time to start climbing by dawn.

Bellies tight, we know that a long day of climbing awaits us. Will we succeed? Will our preparation pay-off? It feels like we're bearing a heavy weight with us, that the success of the expedition relies on how well we can climb on that day.

Pierre climbs the first pitch of the main wall without too much trouble. The difficulty is limited to a short slab boulder, which could be protected by a bomber hand-size cam, before reaching an old Russian bolt (6b/c). After that, one joins the most iconic part of the route: the 250 meters

continuous splitter crack (mostly 5+). It's never hard, as the wall itself is not so steep, and is mostly of hands to fist size. Thrilling.



Jeppe on the 250 meters crack of the start of Perestroika Crack

We felt liberated compared to the cumbersome experience of the day before: no haul line, no faff. We note though that beefy crack gloves are an advantage here, Jeppe was wearing thin ones and thought this section to be quite painful.

The first off-width section (6b+) did not pose much of a problem, if not for Pierre's pants stained red with the blood of reopened scabies from the French Route's offwidth. We knew at this point that the grading of the pure crack pitches would be pretty soft. Jeppe made short work of the second off-width (6b+), by mostly squeezing in the chimney-esque corner crack. That technique, unfortunately, proved fatal for his brand new telephone. While squeezing, his chest pocket opened, and when shouting down that he was safe, his phone decided that life was not pursuing, fell down 40 meters to the height of the bivy ledge and exploded on impact 5 meters away from Pierre. No time to pest though, as we still had 10 pitches to the top, with the most sustained climbing ahead of us.



The fatigue starts settling in

After two pitches navigating crack and flake systems, we were at the foot of the crux of the route: two corner pitches graded 7a/b. A glance at the first of the two pitches was reassuring: crack climbing. It went smoothly for Pierre, as the crack provided solid jams (thin hands to fingers) most of the way, or as nice foot holds appeared on sections with more marginal jams. The steepness of the first part still made the pitch pumpy, but of a good kind: the one that makes you feel like you're actually climbing something steep but without being too strenuous.

After a ledge the second pitch continued in a brownish corner streaked with a thinning crack. The fun, three dimensional approach to the main corner led way to a technical and strenuous dihedral. On his first attempt, Jeppe fought hard, but eventually pushed his foot against the sling of a cam and slipped. He went back up, but having spent too much energy on his first try, whipped. He took out with him a mini-cam, a piton and was thankfully caught by some old rusty beak, before slamming hard with his back on the wall below. Shaken, but not really hurt, it was time to pass over the lead.



Jeppe at the start of the second crux pitch

Pierre could luckily ascend the pitch clean on his first lead, but not without letting out a few grunts and power screams. The resolution to ensure that we would, as a team, get a clean ascent of the route was a strong motivation to keep fighting until the anchor was clipped.

Note: we want to thank Raimundo who re-hammered the pitons on the upper section and made the pitch much safer for us to enjoy.

Relief flowed down on us. We had climbed past the crux of the route, in good time, and the weather looked stable. Our dream was to become reality, we would stand atop the Russian Tower, with Perestroika Crack under us. We had trusted the process, and this route, which seemed utterly ridiculous for us to climb just a year prior, would allow us to stand on its top. We just needed to stay focused and navigate the last pitches.



Jeppe on the last steep section (6b) of Perestroika Crack

Pierre set off again, taking on the exposed slab climbing to follow (6b+). The crux, a blank slab spotted with chicken heads, provided for splendid climbing, although not as exposed as described (shiny bolts helped a lot to provide a sense of safety). From there on, three more pitches of crack climbing led us to the end of the route, not without a last little hiccup. Jeppe started on his ultimate pitch thinking he was to climb a 6a pitch, and therefore left some of the cams with Pierre. It turned out that he was to climb the last off-width step (6c), without the #5 we had borne all the way precisely for this.



Atop the summit, happy

At 17:30, we were standing on top of the summit, but we could not take time to let a sense of accomplishment settle in. We needed to get down quickly, knowing that we would probably get our ropes stuck somewhere on the way. We had just seen the Russians that were preceding us struggle with a stuck rope minutes before standing on top, and that anxiety was gnawing at us. Our ropes did get stuck, twice, despite our care. The first time did not make us waste so much time, as we only had to reclimb 5 meters on easy terrain. The second time proved much more annoying. Pierre had to reclimb almost completely the last 6b pitch, and then downclimb it to make sure that no rope would be stuck again in the many cracks or features.



We had to overcome a last hurdle before coming to the ground. From the shoulder, we thought that it would be smooth sailing as we had rappelled this part before, coming down from the Missing Mountain. In lieu of one of the rappel anchors we had used before - nothing. Or rather, just a naked bolt, without the plaquette. Incredulous, we managed to arrange a new anchor with some tat and by slinging the naked bolt, and finally got back down to the ground around 1:00, knackered.

In the background, Slesova

Jul 21, 2026 How to save the base camp from mud flows

Rain closed in the valley. Forcing everyone back to the colourful tents. Jeppe and I could feel the fatigue from the previous day, and had only one aspiration - rest.

In the morning, a low rumbling coming in from the mountains made itself heard. A while later, we could see some commotion outside, and driven by curiosity, went out of our mess tent. We joined the others and it became too clear what they were nervously looking out. In the distance, we could see a chaos of rocks, mud and water coming down from the couloir between Ortotyubek and the Russian Tower, channeled in the corridor shaped by a stream. Its course was slow, but unavoidable. It seemed harmless at first, but suddenly came to a stop at a narrowing just above the camp. Moments later, the flow escaped that ephemeral dam, and chose a new course, towards our base camp. We watched, powerless, the flow fill our toilet hole, spill in our mess tent, and come threateningly close to our personal tents.



The tip of the mudflow making its way towards our mess tent

Gathering shovels, picks, and anything else that could be useful, work began to make an opening where the flow first stopped and redirect the flow away from camp. After an hour or two of toiling, a sufficient hole was opened and we returned, all muddied to camp to enjoy lunch. Only minutes later came another rumble. Oh no! We all thought, waiting anxiously to see the result of this new run. The opening proved futile, and again, the flow decided that our base camp was a better course for its muddy waters. No further damage was reported, but it was now clear that the new preferred path led straight into the base camp, and to our tent.

We scouted for a weakness in the corridor and opened it up, using erosion to our advantage to dig a deeper and deeper deviation for the water's course. A team of Slovenian climbers who had arrived a few days earlier joined in, helped us redirect the stream and rewarded our efforts with a shot of homemade schnaps. Satisfied, we came back to camp, rinsed ourselves clean of mud, and again, heard the all too familiar rumbling sound. It was unnerving to watch for the tumultuous flow to close in slowly on our new opening. Eventually, it came to us, and without hesitation this time, carved a clean new path away from base camp, following our artificial channel.

Base camp was safe from this worry and we could now enjoy a well deserved rest.

Jul 22, 2026 Rain and rest

More rain. The mood at base camp started becoming gloomy as more and more people fell sick.

Jeppe got infected with the Karavshin bug and suffered the consequences throughout the night.

Jul 23, 2026 Umay Ene: scouting the approach

In the morning, the clouds lifted and Pierre decided to head out of base camp to scout the approach to a seemingly unclimbed and unnamed face towering base camp.

The approach looked daunting from base camp, but scouting revealed that it was much better than expected. An hour from base camp would be enough to reach the base of a step of easy climbing, and from there 10 minutes would be enough to reach the face.

Pierre came back down to base camp and asked Айжан whether the face had a name. She nor her husband did not know of any, so it was decided that it should be called Umay Ene, after the ancient Tengrist goddess of motherhood and children. The face sits down below Kirkchilta or, as the Russians call it Peak 1000 years of Russian christianity, so it was fitting to give it a name with a religious connotation, but with a Kyrgyz origin.



Rest day under the watchful eyes of the children of the staff

Jul 24, 2026 Walking up to the glacier

Jeppe felt somewhat better so we decided to go for a hike and explore the upper parts of the valley.

We walked past the former base camp, through a field of massive boulders, towered by the steep faces of the Wall of Dykes and Odesa. Open pastures with curious cows welcomed us higher up, where we also found remnants of the Soviet era scattered along the trail: the cockpit of a crashed plane, helicopter parts, artefacts of a lost time.

We turned around when we reached the glacier, our gazes staring at the numerous alpine faces that would deserve more attention.

Jul 25, 2026 Umay Ene: a first attempt

The weather stayed shifty, the mornings during these days were generally clear, with the afternoon bringing in unstable weather.

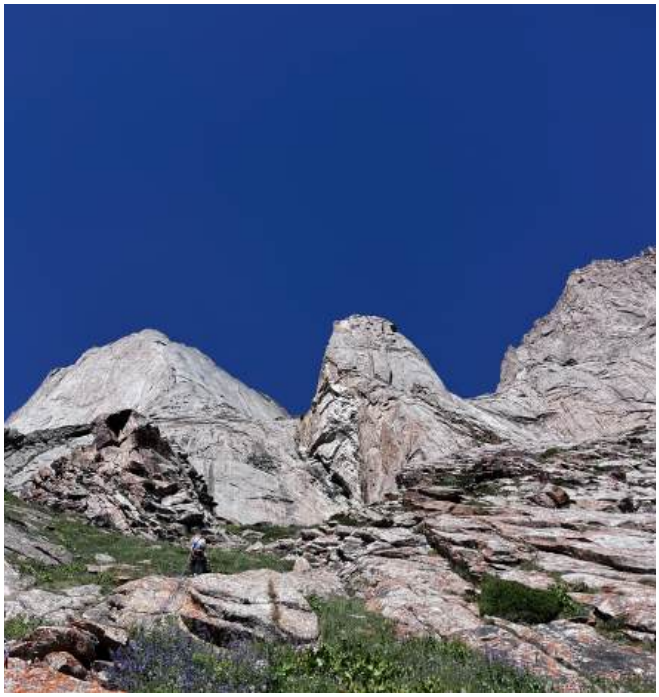
After Pierre's scouting mission days prior, we were motivated to try opening a new line on Umay Ene. From base camp it presented one of the most obvious and natural lines waiting for a first ascent: a very clear corner system finishing up in a large chimney through a succession of small roofs. Potential for some pitches of sustained and interesting climbing, with a more moderate start, on a face whose size was inviting for us who lacked any experience in opening routes.

It also suited itself well for a one day-hit, and in these days of somewhat unstable weather, we thus decided to try our luck.

As we started hiking up to the face, it became clear that Jeppe was not fully healed. Determined to make progress he was though, so on we went, slow and steady, knowing that any progress beyond Pierre's highpoint would take us closer to standing on top of Umay Ene.

After an hour of walking up steep grass slopes, spotted with slabs, we reached a much steeper section, at the level of a few prominent black roofs. In between these roofs, at the uppermost height of the grass slopes we found a succession of somewhat grassy slabs that provided an opening towards the base of the face. 35-40m of easy climbing (5a) later, Pierre reached the end of the slab, and found an anchor built on nuts. Clearly, we were not the first to set foot there. Was the anchor built by climbers coming down from neighbouring Kirkchilta? Or had

Umay Ene already been climbed? Only continuing up would give us the answer. The anchor was reinforced to allow for a swift retreat, a necessity considering both the weather and Jeppe's guts.



The inviting face of Umai-Ene

10 minutes later, we were at the base of the face proper. Many possible options were inviting us. Pierre decided for the most direct line up the face. A reclined dihedral offered interesting yet easy climbing, albeit run-out (the piton we left there, only hammered in by a centimeter or two, bears witness to that), and allowed to join a corner streaked by inviting cracks (50m, 5c R). A rappel anchor confirmed our suspicions: we were definitely not the first ones to climb on this face; to be expected as Umay Ene presents such an obvious face for free climbing, but still somewhat of a disappointment. Unlike Neil Armstrong and Buzz Aldrin, we would not stand on top and find a witty sentence to mark the first human presence there.

The next pitch was more sustained, on steeper terrain. If not for the very grassy start, it would have the potential to be a memorable pitch; just before the anchor, one climbs up on a blank flake where the most peculiar chicken heads offer gym-like holds (50m, 6a+). Again, a rappel anchor. It became clear that we were the first to climb this line, which had been the rappel line for some other, unknown route.

We joined that unknown route on the third pitch (60m, 6a), a grassy splitter crack had obviously been scaled before, bearing holes as scars of that passage, and a bolt protected a slab traverse higher up. We eventually reached the top of the first part of the face, which stops on a substantial shoulder, where we found a bolted anchor. By this point, Jeppe's condition worsened significantly, strained by the climbing. As we had strengthened all anchors coming up, we were back at the base in a blip. The upper wall would have to wait another day.



Crossing the water to get to and from Umay Ene

Jul 26, 2026 Rest

Rest day at base camp.

Around that time arrived at base camp new faces, with whom we would subsequently share our mess tent. A group of young Norwegian guns (Vetle Sevild, Nikolai Atkinson, Severin Schirmer and Sebastian Schadenka) brought a most welcome Scandinavian familiarity. The joining of an Italian team (Giaccomo Vanucci, Filippo Arigoni) allowed us to reminisce of the beautiful routes of Cadarese, and the good humour of a German couple (Lorin Etzel and Kassandra) coloured the atmosphere of our shared meals.

Jul 27, 2026 Take It Easy on the Central Pyramid

Jeppe seemed to have recovered, but wanting to play it conservative on a day with unstable weather, we decided to climb on the Central Pyramid just above base camp. Take it Easy (200/300m, 7a max) seemed as the route with the least slab climbing and thus caught our eye.



Jeppe confused about the second pitch of Take It Easy

It was a fine route, with varied and enjoyable climbing, although the grading is completely off. For us the starting slab (6b+) proved to be the most challenging bit. Run-out, but never really dangerous as the hardest sections were protected with bolts. The top two pitches were memorable; first a sustained dihedral crack (6c), steep but with bomber jams and solid foot holds all the way, and then a final shield striped with thin and uneven cracks which provided delicate yet not so difficult climbing (7a).

As we started rappelling, clouds opened up on us, and we were already drenched by the end of the first rappel. We reached the base soaking wet, with our ropes having repeatedly released their grimy waters on us, but were luckily just minutes later warm and dry in base camp.

Jul 28, 2026 Une Lune Pour Tamerlan on the Wall of Dykes

After the previous day's downpour, the skies cleared up and a generous weather window opened.

We first spent the morning drying our gear, still soaking wet when we woke up, and decided to leave for a two day trip: we would first climb Une Lune Pour Tamerlan on Wall of Dykes (280m, 7a), on top of which is a bivy ledge, from where we would then climb Une Étoile pour Ulugh Beg (600m, 6b+).

Having learned our lesson from Perestroika Crack, we left base camp reasonably early and after an hour's approach were at the base of the Wall of Dykes. The line that Une Lune Pour Tamerlan follows is impressive to look at, extremely steep and navigating some black streaked roofs. We had planned for a little bit more than an hour per pitch of sustained climbing (6c and other), and hoped for a faff-free ascent and haul.

The first pitch showed us very quickly that we would not be able to run up this route's pitches as we had on e.g. The Russian Tower or The Central Pyramid. The first pitch (6c) begins only protected by almost 20 years old pitons, solid looking but on which one would not like to whip, before joining an undercling crack, which had a really wet and slimy section. Extremely pleasant climbing, which always keeps one on the edge. The second pitch (6b+) confirmed that the grades would feel much stiffer than what we had climbed so far in the valley. We made progress, pitch after pitch, without, for once, any issue with hauling.



Jeppe navigating the steep terrain of Une Lune Pour Tamerlan

Time was passing on, inexorably, though.
By the time we reached the start of the crux pitch (7a), night was already falling on us. Jeppe went still ahead, with the hope that if we could climb that pitch, we could more easily continue in the dark on the two easier pitches that followed. He reached a pretty blank section of the wall, where one would need to commit and run it out, which was too much to attempt in the dark. We back cleaned the pitch and then rappelled down the route, our tail between our legs.



A feeling that we would not make it all the way to the top creeping in

This route would have deserved a more dedicated attempt, with more time, for it is one of the most splendid routes (only climbing wise, not esthetically) of the valley. Much steeper than most of

the other routes, on black granite sometimes covered by a shell of limestone. The climbing is always sustained and somewhat insecure, with gear showing up only when one needs it, which makes it so enjoyable if one is in the right mind space. Unique and memorable.

Jul 29, 2026 Rest, Stashing gear for Potankina on Kirkchilta

Waking up the next day, we knew we had made the right decision. By coming down and not forcing it the day before, we knew we would be fresh enough to enjoy the rest of the weather window and attempt a more significant climb.

No rain was forecasted for the next four days. Just what we had been waiting for to attempt a line that seemed like a magnet for our gaze from base camp: The Potankina route on Kirkchilta (1500m, 7a max).

We knew that the route would pose new challenges for us: never had we climbed something so long, nor slept multiple nights on the wall, nor had climbed something so committing: no anchors would offer us a chance to go down.

Again, as we had done for Perestroika, we decided to make our first day of climbing less strenuous by stashing all our gear at the start of the route.

Jul 30, 2026 Potankina on Kirkchilta: day one

Айжан was nice enough to prepare an early breakfast for us, so that we could start climbing by around 08:00. After walking up the steep grass slopes, crossing the end of the steep couloir separating Odesa from Kirkchilta, and scrambling up a hundred meters or so, we were back at our packs.
Above us, the southwest arête was daring us, hiding from our flawed perception its real scale (a common perception bias that makes 300m+ cliffs and faces appear much smaller than they actually are when looking from their base).
Our packs did not feel so heavy as we had feared, despite the 10 L of water we were carrying.

Memories of that day are blurry, with section after section blending together into a uniform sense of a uniform and constant upward push. The climbing was never too difficult (6a/6a+), but never too easy either, continuous, flowy, natural, lending itself perfectly to extending our pitches far beyond the length of the rope, until we would run out of gear.



Jeppe seconding on flared cracks

In that fashion, we reached the arête proper after around 10 or half a dozen rope lengths. While we were expecting to find the bivouac ledge directly after reaching the arete, we were delighted to see that we actually had to navigate on the very airy edge of the arête. The soft, late afternoon light made this one of the most scenic experiences of Karavshin for us.



Jeppe navigating the scenic ridge just before the first bivouac

After a little undesired detour, we finally made it to the bivy ledge, a little terrasse floating in the skies that offered a most welcome nest for our tired bodies to rest. To adhere strictly to the ultra-light principle, we (unwillingly) forgot our sporks and had to eat, very slowly, our food with

our knives instead. That gave us time to enjoy the view of the headwall and let our imagination drift away.



Just before the first bivouac on Potankina, the headwall towering above us



The first bivouac of Potankina, a small nest in an ocean of granite

Jul 31, 2026 Potankina on Kirkchilta: day two

We gave our best efforts at ingurgitating our breakfast, chocolate oats with nuts and started climbing right after daybreak.

We rejoined the arete from the bivouac ledge, and then swirled around in corner systems to join the headwall protecting the summit. Again, the quality of climbing was outstanding. Clean cracks, flared streaks and dihedrals requiring different jamming techniques and body positions made the movement continuously interesting, like a multi step puzzle (6a-6b).
When we reached the headwall, the climbing changed radically. The wall became way steeper and not as featured, making our progression harder, but yet never extreme. Three pitches of piecing out together short and thin crack sections, mantelling moves and steep and shallow lay backing (6b+-7a) led us to a large dihedral.



Jeppe on the headwall of Kirkchilta

We climbed it in a single 60 meters pitch, exhausting our double rack (6c). From there, the summit seemed within a stone throw and we knew that we only needed to stay calm and collected. Our only way out was up, and yet it did not make us anxious. By that time, we had proven ourselves that we were perfectly capable of completing the climb.



Jeppe on one of the last crack climbing sections of Potankina

Two sections of sustained crack climbing (6c-7a) separated us from the easier terminal pitches, which followed a weakness in the final bastion (6a-6a+).
Atop the end of the difficulties, we scrambled up to our bivouac spot, just under the steep south wall of the true summit. We considered for an instant coming down on that same day, but not for long. Soaking the sun at the top of Kirkchilta, without being pressed by time, was as good a reward as one could wish for.



Atop Kirkchilta, happy

Appreciative of the chance we had to be there and dazed by the scenery offered to us, we stayed up until the bright light of a full moon repainted the walls of Karavshin with unknown nuances of black and white.



Summit bivy amongst the clouds

Aug 1, 2026 Potankina on Kirkchilta: day three

The night had been cold at 4500m. Our sleeping bags were covered in frost, but luckily we could warm ourselves in the sun as soon as it rose. Surprisingly, a mouse had nibbled at our trash, sensing crumbs of nuts and chocolate - what a life it must have up there, where no vegetation can be seen.



On the way down to the first rappel anchor of Kirkchilta

Having scouted the day prior where the rappel line starts (in a little col past a subsummit on top of which a huge boulder is balancing), we could get started immediately. The first few rappels gave us a taste of what was to come: low-angle terrain and cracks.
We made sure to be extra careful with rope management, and quickly got the hang of managing coils to feed out rope as the leader goes down.

After 15 or so rappels, we both stopped counting, especially as we were going down unknown terrain, and did not have many known features to use as milestones for our progression.
Most rappel anchors looked reasonably strong, and seemed to have been strengthened if not this year, the year prior (possibly by the successive teams of Slovenian climbers that climbed and rappelled the route).



Rappelling on low-angled terrain, it sucks

At some point, close to an obvious bivouac ledge, the rappel line forks and two possibilities arise. We chose to follow the (orographic) left side as it seemed more directly in line from where we were coming, and closer to the bivouac ledge. That led us out of the main rappel line though. We could see that the quality of the anchors deteriorated, and forced us to slow down the descent to double check all stations. From two beaks being pulled horizontally, to pitons that just come out when bounce testing them, it did not inspire confidence. And it got worse. The rappel line took us close to Umay Ene, where the wall steepened and became almost featureless. The last few rappels were thus anxiety-inducing, forcing us to rely on the gear in

place, as there was sometimes no alternative, nor option to add new gear. But as you can guess as we're writing this report, we managed to reach the ground safely, having redefined our definition of what an acceptable rappel anchor is.

We eventually reached back the base camp in the middle of the afternoon, with a smile rising every time we would turn around and catch a glimpse of Kirkchilta.



Safe, again

Aug 2, 2026 Rest

Well deserved rest at the base camp.

At night, Pierre's guts got really upset. He was finally stricken by the common plague of the base camp: ass pissing.

Aug 3, 2026 Rest, and party at base camp

The mood was festive at base camp. We knew that rain was coming the following day, so we seized this opportunity to have a more social time and throw a proper farewell party for the Chilean group, and Sebastian, whose elbow prevented him from climbing.



Festive evening at base camp

This was a most welcome relief, as for a few hours we could let go of our ambitions and worries for the trip. No more planning, assessing our own form, checking the weather. Just enjoying the company of others.

Aug 4, 2026 Rain and rest

Rainy day.

Айжан honoured us with a plate of raw and seasoned Kurduk. A sort of sashimi coming from the ass of the local fat-tailed sheep. Yum.

Aug 5, 2026 The American Way on The Russian Tower

A period of shifty weather ensued again.

We were by then well rested and ready to try something hard. We could only attempt day climbs with such clouds hovering above us, and did not want to keep ticking cruisy routes as those found on the smaller faces of the valley.

So how best to go big than with the American Way? The route starts hard with the first four pitches in the 7a-7c+ range, three of which are 7c or harder, and the line is stunning, meandering its way up the extremely compact west face of Slesova.



Jeppe on the first pitch of the American Way

Our goal was to climb as high up as we could during the day and come down whenever we would be too wrecked or when the weather would turn. Neither the former nor the latter took long to occur, and we decided to come down from the top of the second pitch, moments before it started raining.

We had no regrets though as the climbing was splendid. The second pitch particularly would be an instant classic for any easily accessible granite crag: a collection of fine and technical boulder problems (max V5/6 each), relatively homogenous in difficulty, but all very different in their execution (slab, thumb press traverse, layback etc).



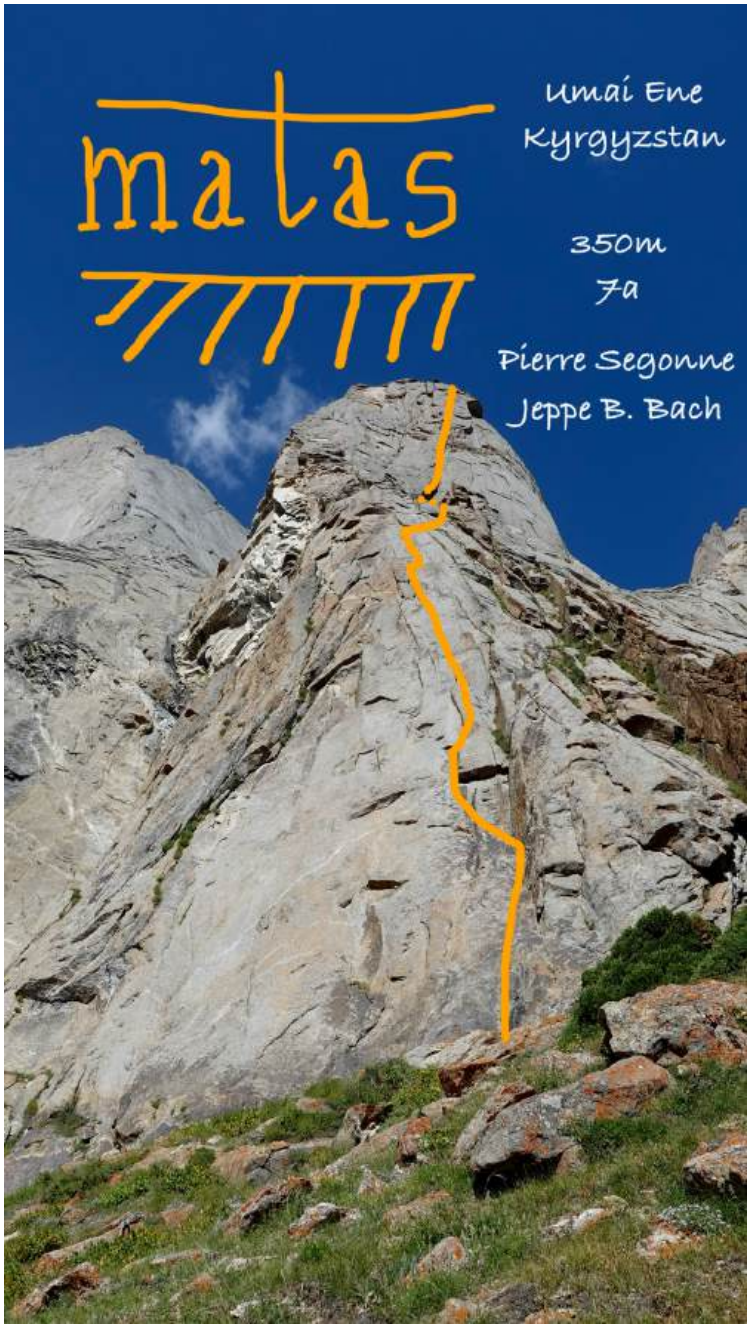
Pierre on the second pitch of the American Way, and falling

We could climb the first pitch clean, and climb all the boulders of the second pitch free, with hangs (many hangs) in between. From our experience, we considered the grading to be on-point, which means that it's much stiffer than many of the older free climbs of the valley.

Aug 6, 2026 Matas on Umay Ene

Again, the weather that day was not giving us clear directions. We knew that the skies would remain clear until mid-afternoon, but had no certainty beyond that. We were determined to go back on Umay Ene and we thought that this day might be as good as any other day.

Without any of us suffering from the nuisance of an upset stomach, the approach quickly led us to the base of the face. This time, we spent more time eyeing openings in the lower part of the face. Further to the right of the direct start, we could clearly see a corner that was leading into a succession of splitter cracks. This seemed a much more obvious start for the climb and so Jeppe ventured on. The line was logical and the climbing well protected and pleasant (5c). After a comfortable ledge, we switched leads and just a few meters above and to the right noticed an anchor with a bolt. The pre-existing unknown route had therefore also taken that same line to start. The second pitch provided glorious crack climbing for close to 60 meters (6a), starting with fingers, to then perfect hands. After that, we rejoined the third pitch we had already climbed, until the shoulder where we had to turn around.



Matas overview

Above us, two options. On the left side of the face, a system of corners and cracks leads to the summit, but from the distance, we could already spot an anchor further up. On the right, a long dihedral rises continuously and directly to a large chimney that opens to the summit. A roof section is protecting the start of the chimney, but we could see a clear splitter crack streaking it, an invitation of some sort. The climbing on the right line seemed more sustained, continuously interesting, and virgin of any gear, so our decision was easily made.



Pierre venturing into the main corner system of Matas

A first delicate traverse pitch (6b+) led us to the corner proper. From there, the next 100 meters in the corner proved to be not as monotonous as we expected (6a+-6b+ range). Some sections require navigating steep flakes, where luckily one could find clean cracks to progress, others forced us onto the slab to the right, where gear can be found when needed, after minutes of cleaning up grass from the cracks. We left two pitons as they are useful to build anchors for the corner pitches.

The crux of the route comes with the roof terminating the corner, a 7-8m finger crack with good feet, which we graded 7a to be consistent with grades of the classic routes of Ak-su (on the softer side). The sky opened up as we had overcome the crux.

Luckily the rain was pretty mellow at the start, so we could let our momentum guide us to the summit, lying so close. The last pitch offered a nice wow-factor and gave us confidence in the interest of the route. A little roof with an off-width crack led way to a chimney sheltering perfect hands-size cracks, before finishing on a last off-width dihedral roof section (#4-5, 6b+).
By the end of the pitch, we were soaked, and were impatient to come down and dry ourselves.



Jeppe onsighting the crux of Matas

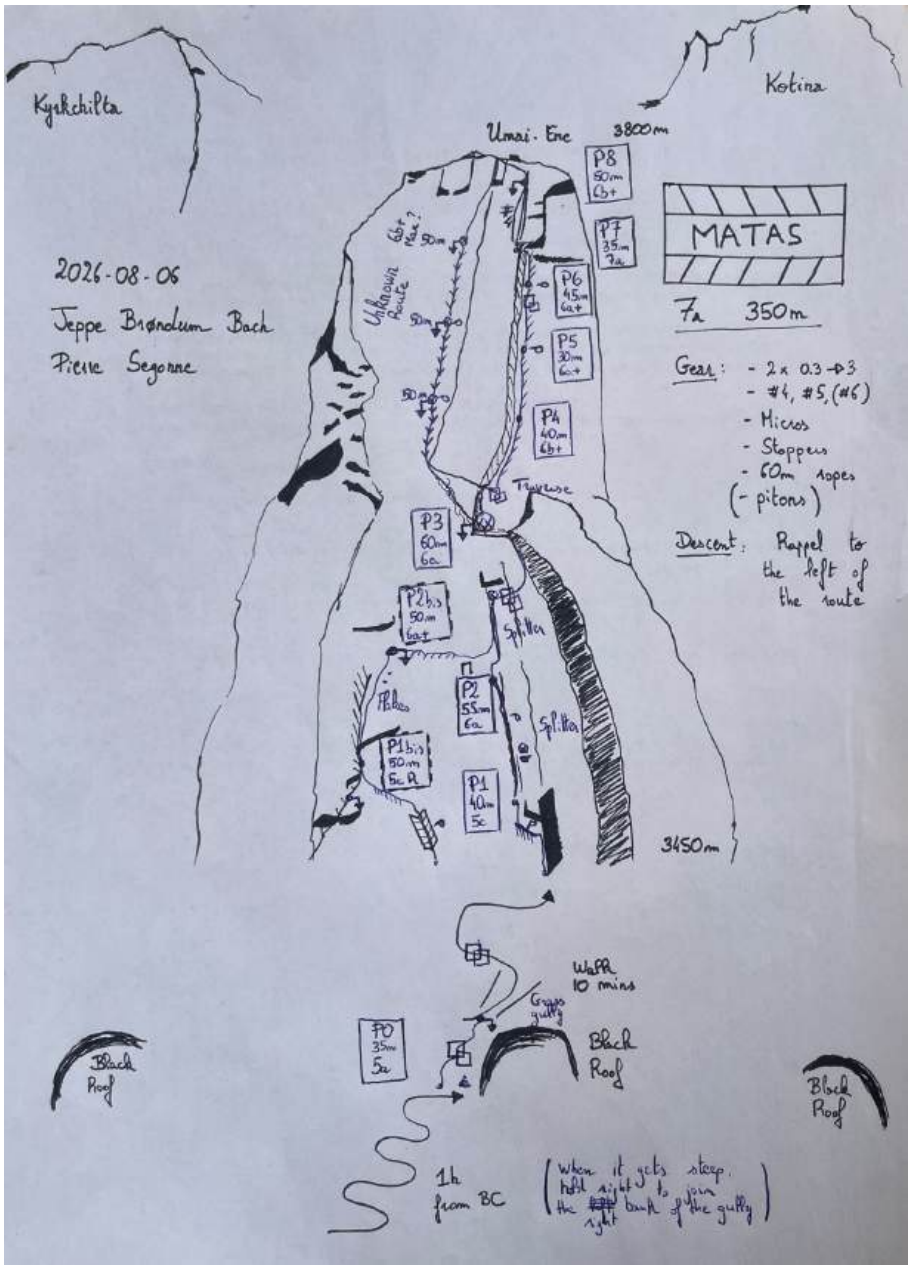
We easily found the anchors of the unknown route, strengthened some of them, and were some time later back just above the base. That's when our rope had the courtesy of getting stuck around a flake. By that time, even the cracks had become soaked and retrieving the rope was a delicate affair.



A wet Jeppe, on the rappels of Matas

Eventually, we did manage to get down, shivering, and anxious about hiking down the steep slopes of the approach. Luckily, rain stopped and the slabs had mostly dried when we reached them, making our descent acceptably safe.

Happy we were when we reached base camp, just in time for a celebratory snack and a most welcome warm dinner.



Final topo for Matas

Aug 7, 2026 Rest

Rest

Aug 8, 2026 The Middle Route on the Little Russian Tower

We had by then decided to explore Kara-Su and join the Norwegian crew there. The base camp had swelled up with many newcomers, and the atmosphere there was a bit tense. We could see that the crew of the base camp was overly busy, trying to accommodate everyone and it was not so pleasant to be there (kudos to them, though, for staying on top of things despite the crowds).

Unfortunately, we could not take quarters there on that day as the Kara-Su camp was full until the next day.

To pass time, and our fingers tingling with the desire to climb again after a rest day, we thus decided to climb the Middle Route on the Little Russian Tower (290m, 6c max). We had heard only positive descriptions of the route, and were tempted to climb something easier, where we could just cruise up the wall.

That's exactly what the route provided: fun and cruisy climbing all the way. After the hardships we had encountered on our previous climbs, this climb reconnected us with the simple pleasure of the movement. The line follows a succession of splitter cracks in the middle of the face, of somewhat constant difficulty, making it well suited to indulge in the feeling of flow, what a pleasure.

Aug 9, 2026 Transfer to Kara-Su

We packed our climbing gear, 2 racks and ropes, some clothes and sleeping gear and went off to Kara-Su. Only two hours separate the two base camps, following pleasant meadows and forested areas.



The faces of Kara Su appear in the distance

We arrived just in time for lunch, and enjoyed our solitude (The Norwegians were the only ones left and had gone for a full day of climbing) surrounded by a new landscape which gave this journey an air of vacation.

Aug 10, 2026 West Face Corner and Cracks on Little Asan

The weather was still unstable, and with three weeks of Karavshin behind us, we did not really have the heart to dash off to some ambitious project.

Route descriptions in Kara-Su were even more scarce and vague. The only short-ish route we found was unnamed and scantily described in a BMC trip report: West Face Corner and Cracks on Little Asan (400m, 7b+ max).

A steep approach led us to a clear gully, which we could scramble up for quite a while. When the terrain steepened, we geared up (Pierre dropping his water bottle which surprisingly survived the 100 meters+ fall) and soon after found bolts mentioned in the description.

To our surprise, the next 150-200 meters of climbing were all bolted, and heavily so. 25 meters pitches, with generally around 10-12 bolts per pitch. Sport climbing in a perfectly protectable corner system in the middle of nowhere. We were puzzled about the intention of those who did that - why would one spend so much time and effort doing this?? The climbing was far from the best we had encountered in Karavshin, the difficulty of the pitch mostly coming from the patches of slime and grass covering the corner cracks.



A clean crack, (grid) bolted on West Face Corner and Cracks

Towards the end of the bolted line, the quality of the line improved drastically though. Just below the summit wall, where the bolts end, we decided to follow the most direct line of cracks, which led us to the ledge below the last pitch with no real difficulties (5c or so).



Jeppe on the last pitch of West Face Corner and Cracks

For the last pitch, we decided to try the harder variation, graded in the topo at 7b+. A pure crack line ascending the last steep wall before the summit. Unfortunately, as Jeppe was trying his best against a seam that was too thin to provide secure finger locks, rain started pouring down on us. He had to bail on a pair of nuts we abandoned there, and we thus rappelled down the line in a well too known fashion at this point: wet.

Aug 11, 2026 Ak-Kalpak on Little Asan

The Norwegians spoke highly of Ak-Kalpak on Little Asan (280m, 8a+ max, 7b obligatory). A short, but impressive line that follows a pillar, high up on the north side of the mountain. The difficulties are concentrated at the start, with a first 8a well-protected dihedral pitch and then an 8a+ traverse boulder problem that can be avoided with a pendulum and a 7a+/b technical section instead.

The approach led us to the circus hidden between the faces of Kirkchilta, Odessa and Asan, one of the most impressive sights to be found in Karavshin. One feels so small up there, towered on all sides by walls of granite too large to comprehend.



Pierre leading the first crux pitch of Ak-Kalpak

Pierre led the first 8a pitch, taking time to complete all links free with hangs in between. Jeppe then set off on the traverse. The valley echoed with his shout as he was taking his first pendulum fall back to the start of the pitch. One of those falls you need to brush up, and start enjoying afterwards. He tried a few more times before a stormy mass fell on us from Odesa. Powerful winds started pushing us sideways, and again, rain caught us before we were able to reach the top.



Jeppe bailing in the storm on Ak-Kalpak

What a shame, as the upper part of the climb seemed to offer some of the best free climbing found in the valley, but the rain washed away all our regrets. For the last time on that trip, we came down to the base camp in rain showers, ready to collect ourselves for the morrow.

Aug 12, 2026 Sourire Kirghize on Yellow Wall

The forecast was finally promising us a full day of good weather, and we decided to seize that chance. The Norwegians were well rested and also ready to climb something challenging. Unfortunately, Vetle could not follow us, impaired by a large swelling on his hand, most likely from too much jamming.

We thus teamed up with Severin and Niko for a social ascent of Sourire Kirghize, a most striking and direct line on the Yellow Wall (600m, 7b max), described by the first ascensionists as “a modern route due to its commitment and long rope lengths”. Perfect.

While the yellow wall’s aspect gets dwarfed by the surrounding mountains, it offers a, rarely found in the valley, clean, 600m high vertical face, sliced diagonally by two gigantic diagonal dihedrals. We were to go straight up the face, finding a way through a series of prominent horizontal roofs.

The climbing starts with two pitches of slab climbing (6a, 6b+), which told us immediately that we should expect stiffer grades than those of e.g. Perestroika Crack. Followed two phænomenal pitches of mostly crack climbing, where the difficulty lay in sections of thin hands/ring locks (6b, 6c). That led us right under the crux pitch, which we eyed anxiously. We could see that a good section of it was completely wet. Fortunately that part did not seem so difficult, so Pierre went on to try his luck. The assessment was correct, and the wet section did not pose so much of a problem. The actual crux proved to be a very sporty boulder problem to come through the roof, protected on bolts (7b). A succession of crimps, reached by contorted body positions, allowed to reach the Hallelujah jug.



Pierre leading the crux pitch of Sourire Kirghize, and falling

Niko managed to send the pitch clean, saving the honour of the team.



A happy Niko on Sourire Kirghize

The next pitch proved to be the most mentally taxing; a long, insecure 60m 7a pitch through a slabby start and then a dirty and slippery narrow dihedral. Rope drag was

such a problem that we both had to build anchors before the official end of the pitch. Two pitches of easier (6b, 6a+), yet still splendid, crack climbing later, we were on the huge ledge that separates the summit from the main part of the face. It was a relief, as we knew that by this point we could come out on top if the weather was to change, as the ledge creeped up all the way to the summit.

Luckily, the weather held, and we could pursue the ascent of the last few pitches. The climbing became less secure, more finicky but still interesting. On the last hard pitch (6c), after 5 or 10 meters, Pierre's left gear loop suddenly snapped, sending most of his gear (a good 10 cams) back down to the ledge. Luckily, Severin was still on the ledge and could hunt for them. All but two were found (phew), but that still left 45m of climbing for Pierre with half a rack on his harness. When in doubt, run it out they say, and so he did.

From there, two easy pitches (5) led us to the summit, which we reached as night was falling. Epic.
Niko and Severin knew the descent from their previous ascent of the Diagonal Route, so they led us all safely back to base camp.

Aug 13, 2026 Transfer back to Ak-Su

We were all satisfied with our time in Kara-Su, rejuvenated by the tranquility (us five were the only climbers in the valley), satisfied to have tried climbs of much different character.

It was time to hike back to Ak-Su though. Our worrying about our visa situation was affecting us, and we wanted to make sure we did all we could to attempt to leave the country in good fashion. Most of our gear was still in Ak-Su, and only there could we arrange our departure.



Vetle, Niko and Severin on the way back to Ak-Su

That was the right decision. When we came back, we could get a hold of the manager of the travel agency who told us that he could not procure the missing documents needed to validate our exit visa application. We thus decided to come back down to Osh the following day, hoping that would provide us with enough time to sort it out.



A last pipe for the valley

Our last evening was joyful, sharing our last beers and vodka with the Norwegian, Italian and German teams and exchanging wishes to stay in touch.

Aug 14, 2026 Farewell, Karavshin

It was without regrets that we left that morning. We could sense that the accumulated mental load had fatigued our minds, and we had completed almost all our objectives. We were coming down as new climbers, enriched with our newly acquired experience and fortitude.

Notable ascents that summer

- Amba on Ortotyubek was repeated by a three person Russian/Kazakh team (Ратмир Мухаметзянов, Макс Тен and Masha?, link). They took three days to climb and come down, and rappelled down the route.
- “Super Perestroika Crack” on Pamir Pyramid and Slesova by Maud Vanpoulle and Guillaume Lagier (link). It’s the combination of Pamir Pyramid (here by the Missing Mountain) with Perestroika Crack.
- The American Way on Slesova by Hugo Meringolo, Isaïa Pozzoni and Dorian Ferrando (link).
- First ascent of Dream is Life on Peak 4300 of Odesa by Filippo Arigoni and Giacomo Vanucci (link).

Reflexions on the development of Karavshin

Karavshin is changing fast. Reports of expeditions from just a few years ago feel foreign, at the time, no official base camp was organised, and climbers had to sort out provisions and transport mostly on their own.

With the efforts of travel agencies, and the opening of the road, Karavshin has never been as accessible, and it can be seen. Like us, many of the people at base camp had never been on an expedition before and were attracted there in part by the simplicity of the logistics. The presence of the base camps is also a great addition for those who simply want to focus on climbing.

In the years to come, it can thus be expected that the number of climbers visiting the valley will keep on increasing, bringing its own set of challenges. How many climbers can stay in the valley before sanitation becomes a problem? With so many already experiencing bowel upsets, it could quickly escalate to a serious issue. What about trash? Right now it seems that most trash is just burned on the spot, but that’s not a viable solution with more traffic in the valley. And erosion? If horses need to travel up to the base camp to carry enough food for 100+ people every day, the trails will quickly erode away.

In the alps, helicopter transport allows to build infrastructure to alleviate some of these issues, but who knows if it will ever be possible there.

Tensions might also arise if Karavshin becomes a really popular destination. Some of the classic routes (e.g. Perestroika Crack) can only accommodate so many climbers per day, and will be a bottleneck at times where the base camp is crowded.

On the other hand, increased traffic can also have a positive effect on the climbing in the valley. With more climbers visiting the valley, we can expect better organisation of the route information. We contributed to that effort by organizing as consistently as possible the existing information on some public databases such as TheCrag. Some routes will also become more enjoyable to climb with more passage, as grassy patches will be cleaned up, making splitter cracks truer splitters.

We hope to see ambitious teams come and set up free climbing routes on the impressive faces of e.g. Odesa, which has mostly been reserved to aid routes until now.

Lastly, while the threat of terrorism has dissipated since the early 2000s, it is unknown whether the new Taliban-led regime in Afghanistan will again host Uzbek islamist groups which could renew their strikes in Kyrgyzstan.

Kyrgyzstan and Visas

Citizens of most countries (list) where you typically find climbers can enjoy a 30 days visa free regime.
Make yourself a favour: DON'T STAY MORE 30 DAYS IN THE COUNTRY

There are several issues with their electronic visa system: 1. The e-visa website is not reliable. From France, it was inaccessible for weeks on end. 2. The required documents are not detailed nor described. More on that later. 3. The processing times provided are not to be trusted. For example, for a normal leave visa, it says that they'll process the visa application within 5 working days, but when you ask them on the hotline, they say that you should expect your visa to be emitted after 6-7 working days. 4. From anecdotal evidence, it seems that they can refuse your application even if you have provided all the required documents. Some Germans at the base camp told us that they had to try twice to get their 60 days visa. Obviously, every time you have to apply for a visa, you need to pay the processing fee.

Our case:

We wanted to be sure to have enough time in Karavshin, so we asked for a 30 day stay in the valley. When you add the transit back and forth, that makes up for 34 days or so in the country. Fine we thought, we can just get the visa extension before coming in. Wrong. The website was down for us until a few days before our departure. Impossible then to get the visa extension in due time. Fine we thought, we'll just get the leave visa, it's just a bit of extra money we thought. Wrong.
We applied in due time for it, but it turns out that it's impossible to complete the application while being in the mountains. We received, and I quote:

Dear PIERRE SEGONNE

Your application reference number 77624037 was returned due to

- Absence Protocol from Police Department with a payment receipt - Absence letter from the Ministry of Internal affairs

What the hell does that mean? Nowhere was it explained what these documents were and how we were supposed to obtain them.

We tried to get our contact at Central Asia Tours to obtain the documents for us, but they could not figure it out.

Realising that no one was really willing to help us, we decided to come down earlier from Karavshin to figure things out. That would have to wait a few days, because police officers also need their weekend off!

Monday saw us come first things first to the police station. Five minutes turned into an hour, then two, then three. After insisting a couple of times on the urgency of our demand, we were finally introduced into the station and could talk to a police officer, who sent us off to see another officer, who of course was absent and unresponsive. What a frustrating experience to wait in that beat up corridor, animated by the sound of policemen playing candy crush or watching YouTube videos. Yet another hour passed. Thankfully, calling the French embassy got things moving. A clerk there fluent in Russian was put on the phone and literally explained to the first officer we talked to what he was supposed to do.

After 4 hours of bureaucratic hell, we were finally out of the station with two Microsoft word generated pieces of paper.

- Absence Protocol: that's the police acknowledging that you overstayed your visa. On it is specified a fine that one needs to pay at the national bank (elbik)
- Letter from the ministry of Internal Affairs: I don't really get what this says, basically that it's ok for you to apply for the leave visa, that everything is in order.

We then proceeded to the bank, and queued again two hours to pay our fine (5500 som for a 3 days overstay..)

One must then upload the two documents, as well as the payment receipt to start the processing of the application.

From there on, you can expect to receive your leave visa in 5 to 6 working days.

The hotline is helpful if you need to transfer extra documents, but will not help you accelerate your application. Note that whenever you write a new message to the hotline, you get pushed to the end of the queue, so avoid at all cost to send multiple messages in a row.

Acknowledgments

We'd like to thank Frilufsland for trusting us and sponsoring this expedition. The gear they generously provided us (approach and climbing shoes by La Sportiva, Gear and headlamps from Petzl), or supported us in acquiring (sleeping bags by Rab/Marmot, water filtration system by Platypus, or some climbing gear, such as Black Diamond camalots) made a big difference for us. Without those, we wouldn't have slept so soundly, nor made it to and back the walls so easily.

We'd also like to thank Peter Harremöes for lending us his portaledge, which unfortunately did not see so much action.

Finally, a big thanks to Jeppe Grejs Petersen for lending his most precious InReach and extra micro traxion!